

La Cañada Flintridge Country Club: Sustainability and Environmental Responsibility

Sam Reyes

University of California, Los Angeles

Environmental Sociology

Dr. Jason Sexton

June 7, 2026

Introduction

La Cañada Flintridge Country Club is a private, family owned golf club nestled in the hills of the Crescenta Valley near the San Gabriel Mountains. This paper uses La Cañada Flintridge Country Club as a case study to ask: How does this private golf club balance real environmental responsibility against symbolic greenwashing, while still operating as a private recreational space shaped by water scarcity, reclaimed water, and member expectations? Although the club was my main research site, its history is hard to separate from the history of La Cañada Flintridge itself. The city was not formally incorporated until 1976, when the neighboring communities of La Cañada and Flintridge became one city.

Long before that, the area's growth was shaped by water scarcity, imported water, residential development, and the desire to protect a quiet foothill community. This exclusivity is absolutely something that has been maintained in the community to this day. On my first visit to the club, I noted the quiet, still atmosphere, almost as if this community was removed from the busier parts of Los Angeles altogether. After researching the area further, I discovered that La Cañada Flintridge was built as an exclusive residential foothill suburb designed to provide affluent Los Angeles professionals with private, estate-sized properties they could use as a getaway. It is important to note, however, that LCF country club, and the surrounding area is built on ancestral Tongva/Gabrielino land, which adds an important layer to its history, especially as this is something that tends to be ignored. Even though the surrounding area was essentially built by real estate developers with a desire to protect the foothill community, LCF country club has a rich history grounded in community, environmental struggles, and environmental consciousness.

History

It was founded in 1962, and the club celebrated its 50 year anniversary in 2012. La Cañada Flintridge Country Club was founded by Bill Godbey and designed by famous golf course architect Lawrence Hughes. The club also boasts a clubhouse which was featured on Architectural Digest. Jack Simison was responsible for designing it, aiming for a mid-century design. Before 1977, the club was member-owned and member-facing, with Gil Dreyfuss acting as the President at the time. After this eventually began to be too complicated, ownership was passed down to Lee and Randy Dreyfuss, Gil's sons.

La Cañada Flintridge country club wasn't built by accident. For the longest time, La Cañada Flintridge did not have a typical modern sewer system. Many residents already had solutions to sanitation in their own homes and were okay with keeping a sanitation district out of their neighborhood. Thus, La Cañada Flintridge's growth was shaped by limited local groundwater and the later arrival of outside water supplies, including water from the Colorado River and Western Sierra Nevada. In fact, Foothill Boulevard, where LCF country club is located, did not have a sewage system until April of 1997, along with the surrounding area.

While this might sound like a bad thing for a golf course, it turns out that La Cañada Flintridge Country Club wouldn't have even existed if it weren't for this nuanced preference by the surrounding community and homeowners. Bill Godbey, the original developer of LCF country club, had been approved to develop 100 homes and 127 apartments but there was a caveat to this. He would only be allowed to develop the homes and apartments if he was able to

reclaim water that was flowing down from above the area he was developing. This was a challenge for Godbey, as finding a use for 200,000 gallons per day of non potable water was a big challenge. However, he decided a golf course, which needs extreme amounts of water to operate every single day would be perfect.

This shows that even though LCF country club was built because this water had to be used, it was also built on the principle of sustainability and water conservation. At the same time, it is important not to romanticize this too much. The course may have been founded around reclaimed water, but it was also connected to private development with a particular vision of suburban leisure only reserved for those that can afford it. That tension is what makes the site so interesting sociologically. Regardless of what the true reason might've been, these principles the club was built on are engrained in the culture, community, and land there, and they have been passed down from generation to generation over the decades.

Field Research

My field research was based on two very informative and engaging interviews with the grounds superintendent, Stephen Garrison, and the director of sustainability and co-owner of the club, Pamela Dreyfuss. Coupled with my own site visits, research about the city and the club's history as a family owned business in sustainability, and extensive research on related scientific literature, I was able to get a solid answer to my thesis question by comparing my findings to peer-reviewed research, other golf courses, and the club's own daily reality, while also tracking the progress that was made over a five year period.

Water

The biggest discovery that I made was regarding the club and its water usage. It is a very well known fact that golf clubs are known for their extreme water usage, as the lush greens and fairways require millions of gallons of water each year just to keep them in a playable condition. Private clubs specifically are often held to higher standards by their members, who often pay tens of thousands of dollars to play golf there, and expect the grass in all areas of the course to be in perfect condition.

Of everything La Cañada Flintridge Country Club does in terms of sustainability, its reliance on reclaimed water is one of the biggest things to highlight, since it essentially exists to use it. When I spoke with Pamela Dreyfuss, she estimated that roughly 70 percent of the course's irrigation now comes from the reclamation plant on the property itself, which is the same plant the club was originally built around (P. Dreyfuss, personal communication, 2026). However, she did explain that that figure has been decreasing for years. Many of the surrounding homes in the neighborhood that feed into this reclamation plant have found ways to decrease their water usage as well. From more sustainable shower heads, to toilets that flush less water, the 425+ homes whose water ends up there have been watching their own personal carbon footprint (P. Dreyfuss, personal communication, 2026).

However, Pamela and Randy are acting on this as they know that they will continue to receive less and less water from the reclamation plant. The club has spent two years pursuing a Measure W feasibility study that would let it capture stormwater currently running untapped through the drains beneath the property, and route it into the reclamation system (P. Dreyfuss,

personal communication, 2026). Pamela explained that their project was selected in April of 2026, in a dramatic tiebreaker vote that ended up going in their favor. If the feasibility study indicates that capturing the rainwater is reasonable, the club will be responsible for paying for the project itself.

One thing that stuck with me during my research is that LCF country club is not the only institution thinking this way. Salgot et al. (2012) argue that in water-scarce regions, irrigating golf courses with reclaimed rather than conventional water has shifted from an option to a necessity for the sport's survival (p. 389). The club's approach even lines up with the watershed's own history. Long before the course existed, water managers recharged the Raymond Basin aquifer beneath the foothills by spreading storm runoff so it would percolate underground (Brick, n.d.). With this key piece of the puzzle, the club's water program is definitely not just marketing layered onto an ordinary golf course, as this information was not public, and difficult to find as an outsider of the club.

However the same reclaimed water that anchors that story is also the source of the club's most stubborn agronomic problem. Carrow and Duncan (2011) explain that the broader pressure to conserve water steadily drives courses toward lower-quality, saltier irrigation sources (p. 1), and they identify "leaching," which is flushing accumulated salt down through the soil with additional water, as the single most important way to manage it (p. 3). Pamela explained to me that this process is also something they've employed when they've encountered their salinity issues, which led me to believe that it is a common process across many golf courses. The scale of the salinity issue is well documented. In a journal monitoring nine Southwestern courses over more than four years, Lockett, Devitt, and Morris (2008) recorded soil salinity ranging from roughly 1.5 to 40 dS/m, with the worst spikes on long-term reuse fairways in summer (p. 2210). Their finding comes with a catch; careful watering can keep salt levels under control, but only if there's enough water to flush it through. Once the water supply gets too tight, the salt just builds up (Lockett et al., 2008, p. 2218).

That is precisely the risk facing La Cañada Flintridge, since its water supply is shrinking. Pamela described the club's solution, which was very similar to the one in the journal. When salts build up, the staff largely waits for winter rains to push them down, and only in serious drought resorts to flushing the greens with potable water (P. Dreyfuss, personal communication, 2026). The trouble is that leaching salt requires water, and the club has to balance trying to avoid using water versus avoiding salinity. As it turns out, the club's objectively most impressive environmental strength is also intertwined with a big problem, which can be managed but not fully solved, and that trade-off is what the Dreyfuss's are still trying to solve.

Solar

While the reclaimed water is the part of the program that predates any talk of sustainability, the club's mission for solar energy is one they deliberately chose to build. The club's 2021 energy audit found that the electricity used to pump reclaimed water uphill, charge golf carts, light up the tennis courts, cool event spaces, etc, made up more than half of its roughly 174 metric tons of on-site CO₂ emissions a year (La Cañada Flintridge Country Club, 2021). Their answer was a planned 500-kilowatt solar array with battery storage, which was projected to cut that number by more than 50 percent (La Cañada Flintridge Country Club, 2021). When I

interviewed Pamela, I learned that the project the 2021 blog had described only as "seeking bids" had actually been built. During our interview, Pamela was surprised that she hadn't updated their website to reflect this new and important change, as it had happened almost two years prior.

As it turns out, the process of getting the solar panels in was not simple. The club's mid-century roof could not hold panels, and the real expense turned out to be trenching the electrical line to the array, which ruled out the sunniest spot on the property and took engineers to solve (P. Dreyfuss, personal communication, 2026). The LED tennis-court lighting alone cost \$50,000 (La Cañada Flintridge Country Club, 2021). While Pamela wouldn't reveal the exact cost of the solar panels with me she mentioned a figure north of 2 million dollars, which is a significant investment for any business, especially a small, family owned country club. It is important to note that this commitment also lines up with the city's own climate plan, which flags building energy as roughly a third of community emissions (City of La Cañada Flintridge, 2016, p. 1).

While the club now has these panels in place, they're unable to say how much any of it actually achieves, which brings me to my first critique. When I asked Pamela how much of the club's electricity the panels offset, she admitted that even her own controller could not pin the figure down (P. Dreyfuss, personal communication, 2026). In my opinion, the headline promise from 2021 citing a cut of more than half to the on-site footprint is exactly the kind of claim that should be measurable by now. However, Pamela did tell me that the club is in the process of adding an AI system, Grid Genius, that tracks electricity use by time of day to cut down both consumption and cost (P. Dreyfuss, personal communication, 2026). It is possible that I simply interviewed her a week before she could've answered my question, but I still think that my critique is valid. Overall, the solar program definitely lands on the tangible side of my central question. The club genuinely spent the money and did the work, but their weakness here was that they didn't do a great job tracking and documenting hard numbers. At the end of the day, the effects on the environment are still the same, but it's always good to know how much progress has been made, especially if any government programs or incentives were to come up in the future which they would need to apply for.

Emissions Audit

Bouncing off of that critique, I think that the clearest test of the club's net-zero goal is not the solar panels, but what the club counts as its emissions. The 2021 audit measured on-site emissions at about 174 metric tons, but estimated that travel for members, guests, and staff driving and flying in for golf and events added roughly 639 metric tons, nearly two-thirds of the club's total footprint (La Cañada Flintridge Country Club, 2021). With that in mind, the solar panels address a smaller piece of the problem. The larger piece is simply that an affluent, car-dependent member has to travel to a private club in the foothills, and the same is true of the surrounding community, where the city's climate plan blames transportation for 58 percent of all emissions (City of La Cañada Flintridge, 2016, p. 1). This is a bit of a grey area, as it is difficult as to who to attribute the carbon emissions to. Is the club responsible for the emissions their employees and members are causing to travel to the club? Or is each individual responsible for their own emissions based on what they choose to do with their lives. Pamela and I discussed this, and she agreed that counting all that travel against the club did not feel fair, and mentioned

the idea of a carbon tax as a fairer way to distribute the costs (P. Dreyfuss, personal communication, 2026).

The club also still has no EV chargers despite member requests, which brings me to my second critique. This seems like a no-brainer for a country club in LA, as the charger could pay for itself with members paying to use the station. This also seems like one of few solutions where the club could have an impact on sustainable transportation for their members and employees. Pamela explained to me that they've been waiting to redo the parking lots before considering implementing EV chargers. (P. Dreyfuss, personal communication, 2026). All in all, the club is still undecided on whether or not they feel they are responsible for what the audit calls "off-site emissions."

Trees and Habitat

The club's work on trees and habitat is one area where there is definitely a line between real sustainability and just putting up an image, because some of it is genuine and some of it is mostly symbolic. On the genuine side is the habitat work Pamela described to me in our interview. The club has been replacing turf in its out-of-play areas with native plants, pulling out invasive mustard plants, running a wildlife camera, and even working toward making the course part of a mountain-lion corridor through the foothills. (P. Dreyfuss, personal communication, 2026). What I found interesting is that the research actually backs this kind of work up. Colding and Folke (2009) found that golf courses had higher ecological value than the land they were compared to in 64 percent of cases, and that this value goes up specifically in places that are already developed rather than near untouched nature (p. 195). This lines up really directly with La Cañada Flintridge, because the club sits in a built-up foothill and not in the wilderness, which is exactly the kind of setting where their research says a course can add ecological value instead of taking it away. They also point out that 40 to 70 percent of a typical course is non-playable land that can support native habitat (p. 192), which is basically what Pamela is describing when she talks about converting the out-of-play areas. Petrosillo et al. (2019) make a similar point that a course's ecological value really depends on the landscape around it, and in this case the landscape around LCF country club works in the club's favor. So I think that this side of the club's work is not just for show.

However, the tree-planting program is another critique of mine. The club has started a Plant-for-the-Planet program, where members can "donate" a tree in somebody's name, as a graduation present, for a mitzvah, etc. The planting of a tree starts at \$150, and Pamela explains that this is a piece of the club's road to net zero carbon emissions. This is fine as a nod to biodiversity. After all, trees are never going to be a bad thing. However, I'm not sure how much carbon this program is really offsetting. A few hundred trees, some of which do not even survive, cannot come close to balancing out a footprint measured in hundreds of metric tons a year. The grass on the course does store some carbon in the soil, which matters for the club's net-zero claim (Qian & Follett, 2002), but how much it actually offsets is exactly the kind of number nobody at the club can give me. It is also important not to take the club's biodiversity claims completely at face value. Colding and Folke (2009) describe something they call the "biodiversity illusionary phenomenon," where a course can raise the number of species at the local level while regional diversity is actually declining, because the animals that do well around people end up crowding out the ones that need undisturbed habitat (pp. 199–200). This isn't to

say that this is happening at La Cañada Flintridge, but it's something to be aware of to ensure it doesn't become a problem in the future. Overall, I don't want to hate on a program that is simply trying to grow more trees, or accuse them of greenwashing. However, it is important to be critical of which programs are having the most impact on the environment, and which programs are just there for show.

Member Expectations

The other half of my research question is how the club balances all of this against what its members expect, and the answer surprised me. Pamela calls La Cañada Flintridge an "entry club," with dues around \$700 a month, which she contrasts with the equity clubs nearby that cost sixty to eighty thousand dollars to join (P. Dreyfuss, personal communication, 2026). Its members are mostly mid-career professionals, not the super wealthy, so the pressure to keep the course perfect does not come from an elite membership demanding control. Pamela went on to say that members like that the club does sustainability work but "don't necessarily want to know too much," and that they like that someone else is handling it (P. Dreyfuss, personal communication, 2026). The only real pushback she gets comes from neighbors who want trees cut for their views, not from members (P. Dreyfuss, personal communication, 2026). This complicates the privilege side of my question since the club is private and affluent but more accessible than the elite clubs nearby. With no real pressure either way, the club has the freedom to do their sustainability work with support from their members.

So far I have been discussing how much of the club's sustainability is tangible or just an image for their brand. The other question that matters is who it actually benefits and who gets left out, which is where environmental justice comes in. Just because a program is sustainable, doesn't mean it can't sit on top of deeper inequalities. When it comes to La Cañada Flintridge Country Club, there are three that stand out to me. The land it sits on, the water it uses, and who actually gets the green space it protects.

Environmental Justice

When it comes to the land, the club's blog includes a Tongva land acknowledgment, but it is worth noting that this was never mentioned in either interview. Stewart-Ambo and Stewart (2023) explain that the Los Angeles Basin is Tovaangar, "the world" in the Tongva language (p. 125), and that institutions across the region benefit from the ongoing dispossession of Indigenous people from their homelands (p. 125). They trace how the land moved from Spanish missions in 1771, to Mexican ranchos after 1821, to private property under the United States after 1850 (p. 142), and they note that the Los Angeles Country Club bought 302 acres of a former rancho to build a golf course in 1902 (p. 139). That detail matters, because it shows golf courses were among the private spaces that directly benefited from Tongva dispossession, and La Cañada Flintridge Country Club is part of the same history. Their main argument is that acknowledgment alone is not enough; they criticize institutions that make statements without action (p. 144) and call for material steps like free education, housing, support services, and returning land (p. 143).

I think a deeper version of the club's acknowledgment could move past the blog toward something concrete. There are a few ways to support Gabrielino-Tongva organizations, such as a land-access agreement modeled on UCLA's, which lets the Tongva gather medicinal plants on

campus (p. 144). Given the native and out-of-play areas the club is already restoring, a similar kind of access agreement is not ridiculous to think about, even though a golf club obviously operates differently than a university. For now, the acknowledgment just markets the club inside a private space, which is close to the opposite of justice.

Water is the second issue. While the reclaimed water is absolutely a sustainable option, and it makes the club more responsible, it does raise the important question of fairness of who gets to use that scarce regional water on land that isn't publicly accessible. Salgot et al. (2012) frame reclaimed water as essential for golf to survive in dry regions (p. 389), which is true, but it still justifies using water for pleasure where supply is shrinking. To the club's credit, it is already moving toward a fairer approach. The Measure W project would capture stormwater and use it to recharge the aquifer instead of buying potable water (P. Dreyfuss, personal communication, 2026), which is basically what local water managers did a century ago when they spread runoff to refill the Raymond Basin (Brick, n.d.). The real problem is that the club cannot prove much of this as of right now. Most of its water and carbon figures are just estimates, and research shows golfers tend to respond to how green a course looks rather than to practices they cannot actually see (Jeong & Song, 2026, p. 10). So if the public is going to accept a golf course using scarce water, I think the club needs to share real, verified numbers instead of relying on its green image.

The third issue is access. Pamela makes a genuine defense of golf as public green space, pointing out that the course provides habitat, recharges groundwater, and can act as a fire break (P. Dreyfuss, personal communication, 2026), and my research partly backs her up, since Colding and Folke (2009) found that courses in developed areas can add ecological value (p. 195). However, in this case the benefits of this particular green space are gated. The club is private, and its environmental gains, along with the property values around it, mostly stay with its members. A more just version would share the green space outward, through public access, youth or community programs, so the benefits are not enclosed behind a membership.

Conclusion

Overall, La Cañada Flintridge Country Club's sustainability program is very well structured and intentional, but could be being measured/kept track of better. The reclaimed water program and the native habitat work are the most important takeaways, since the club was built around the water and the research supports the habitat. The solar panels are having a real impact, but the club cannot say how big (yet). The net-zero goal also depends on what exactly gets attributed to them, and the tree program does more for the club's image than its footprint. What surprised me most is that the club has more substance than image. It barely markets its best work and rarely measures it, which is almost the reverse of greenwashing.

However, I was overall thoroughly impressed with the sustainability work that LCF country club has been doing, and I was personally moved to see how passionate and conscious the owners are about the environment and land that they are on. It is rare in this day and age to see any institution prioritizing sustainability, much less a golf course, and it gave me hope for the game of golf and our world as a whole.

References

Brick, T. (n.d.). Water resources [Appendix E, Water resources technical report]. The Arroyo Seco watershed restoration feasibility study. Arroyo Seco Foundation.

<https://www.arroyoseco.org/FinalReport/WaterResources.pdf>

A technical report on the history and hydrology of the Arroyo Seco watershed, including how the Raymond Basin aquifer beneath the foothills was managed and recharged by spreading storm runoff through gravel beds. It provides the local water-history context for the paper and establishes a century-old precedent for the kind of stormwater capture the club's Measure W project now proposes.

Carrow, R. N., & Duncan, R. R. (2011). Best management practices for salt-affected golf courses: Why and how? USGA Green Section Record, 49.

<https://giecdn.blob.core.windows.net/fileuploads/file/salt-affected.pdf>

A turf-management article explaining how pressure to conserve water pushes golf courses toward saltier irrigation sources, and identifying leaching as the most important way to manage the resulting salinity. It gives practitioner-backed grounding for the salinity problem the club faces with reclaimed water and the flushing workaround Pamela described.

City of La Cañada Flintridge. (2016). La Cañada Flintridge climate action plan.

https://lcf.ca.gov/wp-content/uploads/2024/12/2016_ClimateActionPlan.pdf

The city's municipal climate plan, which inventories community greenhouse-gas emissions and sets reduction targets, finding that transportation and building energy are the largest contributors. It situates the club within local policy and supports the paper's argument that travel dominates emissions at both the club and city scale.

Colding, J., & Folke, C. (2009). The role of golf courses in biodiversity conservation and ecosystem management. *Ecosystems*, 12, 191–206. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10021-008-9217-1>

A comparative study finding that golf courses had higher ecological value than the land they were compared to in 64 percent of cases, with value rising in developed settings, and introducing the "biodiversity illusionary phenomenon." It is the paper's main scientific support for treating the club's habitat work as genuine, while also supplying the caution against over-crediting local biodiversity gains.

Jeong, K.-H., & Song, J. (2025). Effect of eco-friendly management of golf clubs on golfers' behavioral intention to return: Green image, perceived quality as mediator and green marketing as moderator. *Frontiers in Psychology*, 16, Article 1658880.

<https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2025.1658880>

A study finding that golf clubs' eco-friendly management does not directly affect golfers' intention to return, but works instead through green image and is amplified by green marketing. It directly supports the paper's greenwashing argument that golfers respond to a course's perceived image rather than to operations they cannot see.

La Cañada Flintridge Country Club. (2021). Sustainability blog [Web logposts]. <https://lcfcountryclub.com/sustainability/>

The club's own public-facing sustainability posts documenting its emissions audit, solar plans, tree program, and salinity management. It serves as the paper's primary source for how the club presented itself in 2021, which the 2026 interviews then update and test against reality.

Lockett, A. M., Devitt, D. A., & Morris, R. L. (2008). Impact of reuse water on golf course soil and turfgrass parameters monitored over a 4.5-year period. *HortScience*, 43(7), 2210–2218. <https://journals.ashs.org/view/journals/hortsci/43/7/article-p2210.xml>

A 4.5-year monitoring study of reuse-irrigated golf courses in the Southwest that recorded soil salinity from roughly 1.5 to 40 dS/m and concluded that salt stays manageable only if irrigation volumes are not cut too far. It quantifies the salinity problem and underpins the paper's point that the club's shrinking water supply makes salt management harder.

Petrosillo, I., Valente, D., Pasimeni, M. R., Aretano, R., Semeraro, T., & Zurlini, G. (2019). Can a golf course support biodiversity and ecosystem services? The landscape context matter. *Landscape Ecology*, 34, 2213–2228. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10980-019-00885-w>

A study examining whether golf courses can support biodiversity and ecosystem services, concluding that their ecological value depends heavily on the surrounding landscape. It serves as a second source reinforcing that the club's developed-foothill setting makes its habitat work more valuable.

Qian, Y. L., & Follett, R. F. (2002). Assessing soil carbon sequestration in turfgrass systems using long-term soil testing data. *Agronomy Journal*, 94(4), 930–935.

A study using long-term soil testing data to assess carbon sequestration in turfgrass systems, finding that managed turf soils can store carbon over time. It is relevant to the paper's net-zero discussion, since it shows the course's turf stores some carbon even though the club cannot quantify the amount.

Salgot, M., Priestley, G. K., & Folch, M. (2012). Golf course irrigation with reclaimed water in the Mediterranean: A risk management matter. *Water*, 4(2), 389–429. <https://doi.org/10.3390/w4020389>

An analysis treating reclaimed water as essential for golf-course irrigation in water-scarce, Mediterranean-type regions and addressing the risk management it requires. It supports the paper's argument that the club's reliance on reclaimed water reflects a broader necessity rather than just a marketing choice.

Stewart-Ambo, T., & Stewart, K. L. (2023). From Tovaangar to the University of California, Los Angeles: The transfer of Gabrielino-Tongva homelands from time immemorial to the present. *American Indian Culture and Research Journal*, 46(2), 125–150. <https://doi.org/10.17953/aicrj.46.2.stewart-ambo>

A scholarly article tracing the transfer of Gabrielino-Tongva homelands (Tovaangar) through the Spanish, Mexican, and U.S. periods, arguing that regional institutions benefit from ongoing

dispossession and that land acknowledgments must be backed by material redress. It is the foundation of the paper's environmental-justice land thread and its call for the club to move beyond only an acknowledgment.